MODULE 03 · DOMAIN 1 - PROMPTING AND TASK EXECUTION

Anatomy of a Prompt That Works

Task, context, material, constraints, format, examples and role: what goes in a prompt, and why each part earns its place.

DOMAIN 1 of 7 EXAM WEIGHT 14% MODULE 3 of 33

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Claude is a brilliant new colleague who **was not in yesterday's meeting**.

A topic is not a task

WHAT CLAUDE RECEIVED

"Something on the safety rules"

- No task: inform, persuade, or list?
- No reader named
- No purpose or deadline
- No length or format
- No policy attached

WHAT CLAUDE NEEDED

A brief for supervisors

- Draft a newsletter item
- For 300 site supervisors
- So they brief teams by Friday
- 200 words, one action list
- The new policy, attached

THE TIEBREAKER

Name the task, the reader and the shape of the answer. A topic alone gets a generic essay.

The parts of a strong prompt

PART	WHAT IT GIVES CLAUDE
Task	The job, led by a clear verb
Context	Who it is for, what it is for, and why
Material	The documents or data, clearly marked
Constraints	Length, tone, must and must-not
Output format	The shape of the answer
Examples	What good looks like
Role	Whose eyes to see it through

ON THE EXAM

Task and context matter most. Add the other parts as the job needs them.

The task: lead with the verb

- **"Can you suggest some changes?"** gets suggestions. Claude takes the question literally.
- **"Rewrite this paragraph for a client audience."** gets a rewrite.
- **Several asks? Number them.** Three questions buried in one sentence invite one to be skipped.
- **Order matters? Give steps.** Anthropic advises numbered steps when sequence or completeness counts.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Say exactly what you want done. If you want an action, ask for the action.

Context: say why, not just what

A BARE RULE

"Never use ellipses."

- Claude follows the letter
- Has to guess the purpose
- Misses related cases

A RULE WITH ITS REASON

"This is read aloud by text to speech..."

- Claude understands the goal
- Applies it to unlisted cases
- Fewer surprises

THE TIEBREAKER

A reason lets Claude generalise to cases your rule never named.

Context: audience and purpose

- **Who reads it?** A board, a client and a site supervisor need different words for the same facts.
- **What will they do with it?** Decide, approve, act, or just stay informed.
- **What do they already know?** Skip what they know; explain what they do not.
- **What does success look like?** Say it, so Claude can aim at it and you can check against it.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Audience and purpose decide tone, length and detail. Leave them out and Claude guesses all three.

Material and constraints

- **Attach what Claude cannot know.** Halden's policies, figures and client terms are not in its training.
- **Mark each piece.** Headers or tags such as Policy and Last month's report keep instructions and sources apart.
- **Make constraints concrete.** "Formal, no contractions" beats "professional".
- **Remove contradictions.** "Brief but cover everything in detail" cannot be satisfied.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Clearly labelled material lets Claude say which source each claim came from.

Format: say what you want, not only what you don't

ONLY A PROHIBITION

"Don't use bullet points."

- Says what to avoid
- Leaves the shape open
- Claude improvises

A POSITIVE INSTRUCTION

"Write three short paragraphs."

- Says what to produce
- Fixes the shape
- Easy to check

THE TIEBREAKER

Describe the shape you want. Your prompt's own style also leaks into the answer.

Examples: show, don't just tell

- **One of the most reliable ways** to steer format, tone and structure, says Anthropic.
- **Relevant** to the real task, **diverse** enough to show the range, **clearly marked** as examples.
- **Three to five** examples for best results, in Anthropic's guidance.
- **Examples get copied.** If one is only for tone, say so, or Claude may reuse its content.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Describing a house style takes a paragraph. Showing it takes one good example.

Role: whose eyes to look through

- **"Even a single sentence makes a difference"** to focus and tone, says Anthropic.
- **Useful for review:** "Read this as Halden's data protection officer would."
- **Useful for audience:** "Explain this as you would to a new site supervisor."
- **Not a substitute for facts.** A role does not supply knowledge you never gave.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A role shapes perspective and tone. Context and material still do the heavy lifting.

One Halden prompt, built up

PART	WHAT THE PROMPT SAYS
Task	Draft a newsletter item announcing the new lone-working rules
Context	For 300 site supervisors, read on phones, so each briefs their team by Friday
Material	The new policy, pasted under the heading Policy
Constraints	Plain English, no contractions, no more than 200 words
Output format	A headline, two short paragraphs, then a three-point action list
Example	Last month's item, for tone only

ON THE EXAM

Every line answers a question Claude would otherwise have to guess.

From vague request to clear prompt

01

Find the task

What is actually being asked for?

02

Confirm the reader

Who reads it, and what will they decide?

03

Add the material

Gather and label the sources.

04

Set the shape

Length, tone and format.

05

Submit and check

Then compare against the brief.

ON THE EXAM

Task, then reader, then material, then shape. Submitting comes last.

Five ways prompts fail

- **A topic with no task, audience or format.** The most common failure of all.
- **Several asks in one sentence.** One gets skipped.
- **Missing material.** "Summarise the policy" with no policy attached.
- **Contradictions.** "Brief but exhaustive."
- **Shouting.** "CRITICAL: you MUST" can make Claude over-apply a rule. Explain calmly instead.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> When a prompt underperforms, check these five before changing anything else.

> An HR analyst attaches a year of sickness-absence figures and types: "Give me something on our absence numbers."
>
> Claude returns a long, general essay about absence management. The HR director actually wants the three biggest changes since last quarter, for a meeting.

Which change will most improve the next response?

A Ask Claude to be more detailed and more thorough

B State the task, the reader and the format: the three biggest changes, for the HR director, as five bullets

C Switch to the most capable model and resend the same prompt

D Add that the request is very important, in capital letters

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which change will most improve the next response?

A Ask Claude to be more detailed and more thorough

More of the wrong thing. The essay was already too general.

B State the task, the reader and the format: the three biggest changes, for the HR director, as five bullets

Supplies exactly what the topic-only prompt left out.

C Switch to the most capable model and resend the same prompt

A stronger model still cannot guess an unstated task.

D Add that the request is very important, in capital letters

Emphasis adds no information, and shouting can backfire.

THE SIGNAL

"Something on" is a topic. The missing task, reader and format caused the essay.

> A Halden bid writer pastes a weak method statement and asks: "Can you suggest some ways to improve this?"
>
> Claude returns a list of eight suggestions. She wanted the improved text itself, ready to paste into the bid.

Which prompt revision best fixes this?

A Ask the same question again, so Claude has a second attempt

B Add "please be as thorough as possible" to the question

C Upload several more past bids for Claude to compare against

D "Rewrite this method statement to fix its weaknesses, and return the full revised text"

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which prompt revision best fixes this?

A Ask the same question again, so Claude has a second attempt

The same question gets the same kind of answer. suggestions.

B Add "please be as thorough as possible" to the question

More thorough suggestions are still suggestions.

C Upload several more past bids for Claude to compare against

More material does not change what was asked for.

D "Rewrite this method statement to fix its weaknesses, and return the full revised text"

Asks explicitly for the action and the output she wants.

THE SIGNAL

She asked for suggestions and got suggestions. Ask for the action you want.

> Halden's marketing Project has the instruction "Never name clients." Client contracts forbid Halden from identifying clients in publicity.
>
> A new case study avoids the client's name, but describes "a large NHS trust's Leeds headquarters", which identifies the client anyway.

Which revision best helps Claude handle cases the rule did not list?

A. Explain the reason: contracts forbid identifying clients, so leave out any detail that could reveal who they are

B. Repeat the rule in capitals at the top and bottom of the instructions

C. Add a list of every client name that must never appear

D. Remove the rule and have marketing edit every draft by hand

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which revision best helps Claude handle cases the rule did not list?

A Explain the reason: contracts forbid identifying clients, so leave out any detail that could reveal who they are

The reason lets Claude generalise beyond names to any identifying detail.

B Repeat the rule in capitals at the top and bottom of the instructions

Louder, not clearer. Claude already obeyed the rule's letter.

C Add a list of every client name that must never appear

Names were never the problem. The leak was a description.

D Remove the rule and have marketing edit every draft by hand

Gives up on a fixable instruction, and invites slips.

THE SIGNAL

Claude kept the letter of the rule and missed its purpose. Give it the purpose.

> Halden's learning team asks Claude for multiple-choice quiz questions for each safety course. The house format is strict: a short scenario, four options and a one-line reason.
>
> A paragraph describing the format is in the prompt, but every batch comes back laid out slightly differently.

Which addition will most reliably fix the format?

A. A longer, more detailed paragraph describing the format

B. Three to five varied questions in the house format, clearly marked as examples

C. A line asking Claude to keep the formatting consistent

D. A switch to a more capable model for the quiz work

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which addition will most reliably fix the format?

A. A longer, more detailed paragraph describing the format

More telling. The description already exists and is not landing.

B. Three to five varied questions in the house format, clearly marked as examples

Examples are among the most reliable ways to steer format.

C. A line asking Claude to keep the formatting consistent

Consistent with what? It names no target.

D. A switch to a more capable model for the quiz work

The gap is in the prompt, not in capability.

THE SIGNAL

A strict format, described but not shown: show it.

> A Halden account director forwards a note to an analyst: "Can Claude do something about the client complaints?" A spreadsheet of last quarter's complaints is attached.
>
> The analyst wants to turn the note into a proper prompt.

Which step should come first?

A Decide the output format, such as a table or a short report

B Attach the complaints spreadsheet and label it clearly

C Work out the actual task hidden in the note, with the account director

D Choose which Claude model to use for the analysis

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which step should come first?

A Decide the output format, such as a table or a short report

Format depends on the reader and task, which are not yet known.

B Attach the complaints spreadsheet and label it clearly

Needed, but which data matters depends on the task.

C Work out the actual task hidden in the note, with the account director

Everything else depends on what is really being asked.

D Choose which Claude model to use for the analysis

Model choice follows the task. Choosing first is backwards.

THE SIGNAL

"Do something about" hides the task. Find it before anything else.

> Halden's operations manager asks Claude for "a brief summary, under 100 words, that covers every one of our 40 northern sites in full detail".
>
> Each attempt either runs far over length or skips most of the sites.

What is the best fix?

A. Add an example of a good summary from another region

B. Switch to a more capable model and try again

C. Ask Claude to do its best within the instructions

D. Resolve the conflict: a short summary of the sites that need attention, with the full detail in a separate table

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best fix?

A. Add an example of a good summary from another region

An example cannot make contradictory constraints compatible.

B. Switch to a more capable model and try again

No model can satisfy both limits at once.

C. Ask Claude to do its best within the instructions

That is what it was doing: sacrificing one constraint each time.

D. Resolve the conflict: a short summary of the sites that need attention, with the full detail in a separate table

Decides the priority, and gives each need its own place.

THE SIGNAL

Under 100 words and full detail on 40 sites cannot both be true. Choose.

In five lines

- **The golden rule:** if a colleague with no context would be confused, so will Claude.
- **Seven parts:** task, context, material, constraints, format, examples, role.
- **Say why**, and say what to do, not only what to avoid.
- **Show the format** with three to five marked examples when describing it fails.
- **Vague request to prompt:** task, reader, material, shape, then submit.

> COMING UP
>
> Next: decomposition, for tasks too big for one prompt.